

Once in the virtual memory settings (see §8.2.1), you can see all your partitions listed in the box. Select the drive on which to enable the page file, then select ‘Custom size’, and key in an appropriate size for the page file as discussed in the previous section. You can also span the page file across several partitions by selecting each drive and repeating the process as discussed above. In fact, many believe that a small amount of page file should reside on the OS-loaded drive, and that the remaining should be spanned across the other drives to improve performance.



The page file on a non-OS drive

8.3 Services

Windows XP is perhaps the best operating system Microsoft has been able to deliver till date. Despite its complexity, XP poses no challenge to a beginner or seasoned pro when it comes to operating the system—the interface is slick, precise and intuitive. However, behind this slick interface lies a demon that hogs system resources like no other operating system does.

The reason for system resources vanishing is the barrage of services running in the background. All modern OSes constantly run processes that monitor the surrounding changes regardless of user or application inputs. These processes enable the OS to perform certain actions such as launching of applications, detection of plug-and-play devices, monitoring of network resources, file indexing, and so on. In XP terminology, these processes are called “Services,” and they run in the background without user intervention or knowledge.